



Nitrous oxide is a common way to manage the pain of contractions. Your midwife will guide you so that you know when to inhale for the most effective pain relief.

A HISTORY OF PAIN RELIEF

The history of modern obstetric pain relief began in the mid-19th century with the discovery of chloroform. Nitrous oxide and opioids followed; at the start of the 20th century, enthusiasm for pain-relieving drugs was so great that they were overused, with women in labor in a state of near-unconsciousness. The natural childbirth movement in the 1960s and 1970s was a reaction to such overuse of drugs. In the 1970s another revolution was at hand as epidurals became available.

Opioids

These belong to a group of drugs called narcotics and are sleep-inducing. They are similar to morphine and include drugs such as Demerol. They attach themselves to receptors in the brain or nerves and block the transmission of pain.

OPIOIDS (PETHIDINE AND DIAMORPHINE)

Advantages

- Opioids help you to relax during labor, which can help you to conserve your energy between contractions.
- Opioids can produce a feeling of well-being, which many women find beneficial during labor.

Disadvantages

- Many women report feeling nauseated with opioids, which can be an unexpected and unpleasant side effect on top of your pain and contractions.
- Opioids can cause dizziness, and this can be disorienting during labor.
- Some women have reported feeling out of control with some opioid medications and therefore out of touch with how their labor is progressing.